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From Coding to Conversation: A New Methodological Framework for AI-Assisted Qualitative Analysis

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Abstract

The rapid emergence of generative AI tools challenges traditional assumptions about qualitative data analysis, particularly the central role of coding. This article introduces Conversational Analysis to the Power of AI (CA^{AI}), a novel methodological framework that replaces coding with structured, dialogic interaction between researchers and large language models. CA^{AI} reimagines analysis as a process of iterative questioning, synthesis, and reflexive interpretation rather than segmentation and categorization. Grounded in a hermeneutic epistemology and emphasizing methodological rigor, CA^{AI} integrates inductive, deductive, and abductive reasoning strategies. It allows researchers to adapt procedures from established methods like Grounded Theory while embracing a distributed and co-constructive model of knowledge creation. The article outlines a five-step process for CA^{AI}, discusses reliability and validity in this new paradigm, and positions the approach within broader shifts toward post-coding qualitative inquiry. CA^{AI} offers a compelling alternative for researchers seeking to deepen interpretation, democratize analytic access, and expand the epistemic horizons of qualitative research in the age of AI.

Keywords

conversational analysis with AI, qualitative analysis with AI, methodological framework for using AI for analysis, post-coding analysis, CA to the power of AI

Introduction

The rapid emergence of generative artificial intelligence (genAI) tools is profoundly reshaping how researchers engage with unstructured data, particularly within qualitative analysis. While these advancements offer exciting possibilities, they also bring challenges. Traditional qualitative coding methods, though rigorous, are often time-intensive. Conversely, while general-purpose chatbots and large language models (LLMs) offer speed, they frequently fall short in providing the necessary rigor, transparency, and traceability crucial for sound qualitative inquiry. Many current applications claiming to automate qualitative analysis often perform tasks closer to classification proxies rather than engaging in the deep, interpretive work characteristic of the field.

This article questions the continued reliance on coding as the dominant analytic procedure in many qualitative research traditions in light of new technological possibilities It argues that coding, once an essential cornerstone of qualitative analysis, may now be effectively replaced by AI-supported data retrieval combined with dialogue-based interpretation. As a way forward, a novel methodological framework is introduced: Conversational Analysis to the power of AI (CA^{AI}), proposing a shift toward interactive, co-analytic engagement with qualitative data. Furthermore, the article delves into the fundamental epistemological questions surrounding how knowledge is constructed when AI becomes part of the analytic process and proposes concrete strategies for ensuring quality within this new dialogic framework.

Qualitative Coding vs. LLM-Driven Classifications

As the use of large language models (LLMs) in qualitative research gains momentum, it becomes increasingly important to distinguish between two fundamentally different approaches to textual analysis: real qualitative coding and what may more accurately be described as classification proxies. While many recent studies claim to automate or

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accelerate qualitative analysis with generative AI, closer examination reveals that they often bypass the very practices that define interpretive, in-depth qualitative work—and this closely relates to the institutional and disciplinary affiliations of authors.

Papers authored by researchers from computer science, data science, or human-computer interaction (HCI) departments (e.g., Gao et al., 2023; Xiao et al., 2023; Zackary, 2024; Zhang et al., 2024) typically adopt an engineering mindset—treating qualitative data as text to be segmented, labeled, or clustered using LLMs. These projects frequently rely on custom tools, API pipelines, and pre-processed datasets, often reducing analysis to a set of classification tasks, which requires chunking the text. Chunking, however, destroys the continuity that is essential for making interpretive leaps in qualitative analysis. In addition, the number of codes applied is mostly small (usually under 10), and the datasets—while sometimes described as "large"—consist mostly of short texts like survey responses or tweets.

By contrast, studies authored by qualitative researchers from fields like sociology, education, health, or communication (e.g., Goyanes et al., 2025; Hayes, 2025; Hitch, 2024; Lixandru, 2024; Perkins & Roe, 2024) tend to emphasize interpretation, reflexivity, and transparency. These authors often work directly with interview transcripts or focus groups, engage with models through dialogue, and reflect critically on the limits and affordances of generative AI. In many of these studies, coding is not merely a function of labeling text but a theoretical, iterative, and contextual process.

Traditional qualitative coding is not simply the act of assigning labels to text. It is an iterative, interpretive, and contextually grounded process that unfolds over time. Researchers typically engage with full transcripts—often ranging from 10 to 35 interviews—developing between 80 and 250 distinct codes, frequently arranged into hierarchical categories and subcodes. What distinguishes this process is not just the volume or granularity of codes, but the emergence of insight through repeated immersion, reflection, memoing, and reconfiguration.

Qualitative coding is also deeply dialogic and theory informed. Analysts shift between inductive openness and deductive structure, exploring contradictions, emotional tone, and the subtle meaning behind participants' words. The goal is rarely just thematic description, but interpretive depth, often culminating in the development of conceptual categories, metaphors, or grounded theories.

In contrast, many studies claiming to perform "qualitative analysis" with LLMs (e.g., GPT-3.5, GPT-4, Claude 2) are actually conducting shallow classification over small or pre-segmented datasets. For example, Zackary (2024) had ChatGPT code 232 pre-defined text passages using just nine codes in three categories—a setup that bears closer resemblance to quantitative content analysis than to qualitative inquiry. Similarly, Xiao et al. (2023) applied 9 predefined categories to 668 survey questions. While these tasks are framed as "qualitative coding," they lack the scope, complexity, and context integration typical of real coding practice.

Even when studies use inductive approaches, such as in Deiner et al. (2024) or Perkins and Roe (2024), LLMs tend to produce a small number of high-level themes—often five to ten—with little depth or sub-coding. What's more, these outputs are often non-reproducible, context-blind, or overly reliant on surface-level phrasing. This tendency is amplified by constraints in prompt design and the inability of many systems to maintain memory across large document sets (Gamieldien et al., 2023).

What much of this emerging literature reflects is not the automation of qualitative coding, but a redefinition of the task to fit the model's limitations. Rather than expanding the epistemic reach of qualitative methods, LLMs are often used to simplify or flatten them into labeling exercises, where meaning is predefined or extracted from context-free units. This approach may generate speed, but it sacrifices reflexivity, nuance, and methodological rigor.

Toward a More Responsible Use of LLMs

Rather than trying to utilize genAI technology to replace coding in qualitative analysis, it is more productive to consider how LLMs naturally work and what they have been built for. As Hayes (2025) and Ibrahim and Voyer (2024) suggest, meaningful use of generative AI requires dialogic interaction, theoretical framing, and critical engagement. The promise of LLMs in qualitative research lies not in mimicking coding software, but in supporting new methods of inquiry that preserve the interpretive richness of the field. Recognizing the difference between classification proxies and real qualitative coding is essential if we are to ensure methodological integrity in this rapidly evolving space.

One might object that, even when conversationally using LLMs, generative AI still performs a form of "coding," since textual data are converted into numerical representations (via tokenization and embeddings) and then organized according to statistical relationships in a high-dimensional semantic space. However, this computational encoding process should not be conflated with qualitative coding. The former is a mathematical transformation that enables the model to navigate patterns across vast linguistic contexts, whereas qualitative coding is a meaning-making practice grounded in reflexive interpretation, theoretical positioning, and situational judgment. Treating statistical vectorization as equivalent to conceptual coding collapses the essential distinction between semantic interpretation and representational patterning within a probabilistic language model.

Hybrid Solutions: Traditional Coding Tools Enhanced With Generative AI

As generative AI (GenAI) advances, established CAQDAS platforms like MAXQDA, ATLAS.ti, and NVivo have begun integrating AI features—not to replace traditional coding workflows, but to enhance them. These hybrid solutions preserve methodological continuity while improving efficiency in early tasks like data familiarization, code development, and synthesis. MAXQDA's AI Assist exemplifies this trend. Rooted in formal frameworks, it supports both concept- and data-driven coding. Researchers stay in control, using AI as a second coder or brainstorming partner, especially during pilot phases (Friese, forthcoming). In contrast, ATLAS.ti opts for full-scale automation: it codes paragraph by paragraph without tracking meaning across documents, often generating hundreds of fragmented codes. The result is a time-consuming cleanup process and a lack of methodological coherence.

This divergence prompted me to question whether coding itself remains necessary, as expressed in my early writing on this topic: "Rethinking Qualitative Data Analysis" (Friese, 2023b), "Life Without Coding" (Friese, 2023a), and "Ethical and Responsible Use of AI" (Friese, 2024). Instead, I proposed that dialogic, real-time engagement with data offers a more natural, flexible path. Platforms are starting to reflect this shift. MAXQDA's Tailwind feature, for instance, allows exploration without applying codes, signaling broader acceptance of alternative analytic paradigms. With the rise of conversational AI, semantic search, and retrieval-augmented generation, we're entering an era where coding may no longer be essential. Instead of tagging data with static labels, researchers can now interact with their material, probing meanings dynamically and contextually. This evolution raises deeper questions about how we construct knowledge in qualitative research—when the tools themselves start to reshape what it means to analyze.

What It Means to Know: Epistemological Shifts in AI-Assisted Qualitative Analysis

Traditionally, qualitative inquiry has been grounded in the interpretive paradigm, where knowledge is constructed through the immersive engagement of researchers with empirical material, situated within social contexts and informed by theoretical perspectives. Meaning does not reside *in* the data but *emerges* from a dialogic, recursive relationship between analyst, context, and text. Knowing, in this frame, is deeply connected to the knower's positionality, experience, and reflexive engagement.

As Krähnke et al. (2025) and Schäffer and Lieder (2023) argue, a hermeneutic epistemology is particularly well-suited to conceptualizing how AI might be meaningfully integrated into qualitative analysis. In this view, knowledge is constructed dialogically—through the interaction between researcher, text, and interpretive horizons. When AI is added to the equation, it does not replace the researcher but becomes part of a triadic interpretive space, one in which the LLM's outputs act as provocations that the researcher responds to, questions, and situates. The act of understanding becomes a process of navigating between perspectives: that of the participant, the AI model, and the researcher's own evolving framework. The hermeneutic circle is not broken but widened.

The AI model becomes a new epistemic actor that simulates understanding through probabilistic modeling. Even though these models lack *Seinsverbundenheit*—the ontological embeddedness in lived, socio-historical worlds that informs human interpretation (Gadamer, 1960; Mannheim, 1936). Thus, they do not *experience*, *feel*, or *reflect* in the ways human researchers do. Yet, paradoxically, their output can still offer viable insights, precisely because they are trained on vast and socially-situated corpora.

This raises a fundamental epistemological question: if AI-generated interpretations are not grounded in human consciousness or lived experience, can they nevertheless support meaningful qualitative analysis? The answer, as Krähnke et al. (2025) suggest, depends less on what AI is and more on how it is used. Large language models can serve as abductive catalysts—resulting in researchers gaining unexpected insights, challenging established assumptions, and inviting new interpretive directions. Their outputs do not arise from understanding in a human sense, but from vast intertextual exposure. The digital traces that fuel their training are themselves reflections of the lifeworlds we seek to study—and many more that lie beyond our personal reach. In this sense, the "knowledge" produced by AI is not personal but collective and distributed, an aggregated echo of meaning-making across diverse social, cultural, and discursive contexts (Hoffmann et al., 2025; Schäffer & Lieder, 2023).

While this distributed knowledge space extends far beyond what any individual researcher could encounter in a lifetime, it remains uneven. The training data of most LLMs overrepresent dominant Western discourses and underrepresent marginalized or non-digitized voices. This imbalance does not invalidate their use, but it does require critical awareness of how certain linguistic and cultural framings may be more easily surfaced than others.

Concerns about LLMs reinforcing dominant Western discourses are legitimate when models are used to generate interpretations directly from their training priors. In those cases, the risk is that marginalized perspectives may be overshadowed by statistically dominant voices embedded in global training data. However, in a dialogic, data-grounded use such as in the suggested framework, the LLM is not asked to replace the researcher's interpretive work or produce culturally neutral judgments. Instead, it is tasked with retrieving and reorganizing meaning strictly within the boundaries of the interview material provided by the researcher. This means that the interpretive space is anchored in the actual voices of participants—including marginalized voices present in the dataset—rather than in generalized patterns from the model's pretraining.

In this mode, the LLM functions as a pattern amplifier within the researcher's data, not as an external cultural authority. The researcher, who possesses contextual, relational, and embodied understanding of participants—particularly in work involving vulnerable or marginalized communities—remains the one who evaluates resonance, relevance, and ethical adequacy of any AI-assisted insight. When used this way, an LLM does not overwrite vulnerable voices with globalized generalizations but supports the researcher in seeing connections, tensions, and contrasts within the voices already present in the project.

The risk of dominance bias shifts, therefore, from silencing data participants to subtly framing abductive suggestions in majority discourse terms. This is a real concern, but it is one that requires reflexive monitoring, not rejection of the technology altogether (Nguyen & Welch, 2025). A critically trained qualitative researcher can easily recognize when a model's suggestions drift toward culturally generic framings and respond by re-anchoring the dialogue in the participant's own language, worldview, and lived context.

Engaging with LLMs allows researchers to access perspectives that may otherwise remain inaccessible. These models can introduce interpretive angles, nuances, or contrasts that extend the scope of human inquiry. When used dialogically and iteratively, they become tools for epistemic expansion, offering a form of methodological triangulation: not between data sources, but between human insight and machine-generated associations. In this configuration, researchers do not cede authority to the model, but remain in control—accepting, rejecting, or refining AI outputs in light of their theoretical, contextual, and ethical frameworks.

These developments compel us to revisit what counts as qualitative knowledge. Must it always stem from human immersion alone, or can it also arise from orchestrated interactions with systems that mirror, provoke, and extend human sense-making? The epistemological terrain is shifting: from individual hermeneutics to distributed intelligence; from solitary interpretation to dialogic co-analysis. In this space, knowing is less about ownership and more about orchestrating meaningful epistemic encounters—between researcher, data, and AI model.

The idea that knowledge emerges through interaction rather than from a single mind predates AI. Ideas of knowledge as relational and distributed have long existed. Deleuze and Guattari's concept of assemblage (agencement) frames meaning-making as an emergent effect of heterogeneous constellations of humans, discourses, tools, affects, and material conditions rather than the product of an isolated subject (Deleuze & Guattari, 1975, 1980). Similarly, Hutchins' work on distributed cognition demonstrates how navigating a ship is not the cognitive achievement of a single captain, but a coordinated process involving crew members, instruments, environmental cues, and the material behavior of the ship itself (Hutchins, 1995). From this perspective, generative AI does not generate meaning autonomously but can act as one element within a contemporary assemblage of knowledge creation in which human researchers actively interpret, critique, and recontextualize its contributions.

As we move toward more dialogic, reflexive forms of AI-assisted inquiry, we are not abandoning qualitative principles but reimagining them. The challenge is not to preserve tradition for its own sake, but to ensure that the emerging practices—however novel—remain grounded in the ethical, contextual, and interpretive commitments that define the field.

Emerging Practices of Post-Coding Analysis

Above, we already challenged the assumption that coding is intrinsic to qualitative analysis and argued that, in light of LLM capabilities, a new mode of inquiry is not only possible but increasingly necessary. How do we ensure rigor, reflexivity, and conceptual depth in an environment where categorization is no longer a prerequisite? These are the questions explored in the next section, which shows that coding-free analysis is not merely speculative but already emerging in practice.

Several researchers are beginning to chart pathways toward post-coding analysis—tentatively at first, often using commercially available tools like ChatGPT. Yet many of these efforts still reflect a partial adherence to the logic of classification that has long structured qualitative research. Hayes (2025) exemplifies a hybrid approach that begins with traditional coding logic but moves decisively toward interactive engagement with AI. His process starts by asking GPT-4 and Claude 3.5 to generate a thematic coding framework based on full interview transcripts and to classify documents according to these themes. For instance, Claude outputs a codebook and a table indicating whether specific codes appear in each document, along with a few illustrative quotes. While this reflects a classification mindset, Hayes does not stop there. The second phase of his analysis shifts toward dialogic exploration. Using the thematic scaffolding as a starting point, Hayes engages the LLMs in more dynamic tasks: he prompts them to compare perspectives across cases, simulate policy debates, or reflect on contradictions in the data. In doing so, he treats the LLM less as a coding engine and more as a conversational partner—albeit one whose outputs are treated with caution and constantly evaluated against the researcher's interpretive framework.

Perkins and Roe (2024) move a step further away from coding. Working with institutional policy documents, they use ChatGPT to suggest high-level themes and then request quotations to support or refine those themes. Unlike Hayes, they do not construct or apply a formal codebook, nor do they attempt comprehensive classification. Instead, the LLM is used for pattern recognition and plausibility checks, with the human researcher validating outputs. Their approach decouples theme development from data segmentation, treating the AI as a thematic assistant, while reasserting human control over interpretation and trustworthiness. The analysis remains descriptive, but their method clearly signals a departure from the rigid mechanics of coding.

Morgan's (2025) Query-Based Analysis (QBA) pushes this line of thought further. He presents a structured, reflexive alternative to traditional coding, grounded in a three-step process that blends inductive logic with iterative dialogue. The approach begins with broad, undirected queries posed to an LLM in a chat interface. These initial prompts—formulated with careful contextual framing—are used to elicit a range of high-level themes from the data, serving as entry points for deeper inquiry. Rather than seeking a single definitive answer, Morgan emphasizes the practice of prompt engineering, comparing responses to differently phrased questions and selecting the most meaningful set of candidate themes based on the researcher's familiarity with the data and interpretive goals.

In Step 2, the researcher follows up with more specific queries, targeting each of the previously identified themes to elaborate potential subthemes. These prompts allow for the surfacing of overlapping or interrelated concepts, which are then refined, consolidated, and evaluated by the researcher. This process highlights Morgan's emphasis on reflexivity and analytic judgment—recognizing that subthemes are not fixed categories but evolving conceptual constructs that gain clarity through iterative engagement.

The final step, Step 3, focuses on substantiating themes and subthemes with supporting quotations. While this resembles traditional thematic presentation in qualitative reporting, the path to these findings has been dialogic rather than classificatory. The LLM functions not as a coding engine, but as a responsive partner for exploration, returning to specific passages when queried and allowing researchers to combine theme-based and relational searches. QBA therefore offers a compelling post-coding framework: one that retains structure and transparency, yet dispenses with segmentation and labeling as a prerequisite for analysis. It positions the LLM as an iterative thinking tool, with the human researcher maintaining epistemic authority throughout. While the analysis leans descriptive, QBA provides a lightweight, adaptable alternative to manual coding, especially valuable for researchers seeking analytic traction without the burden of segmentation or labeling. It signals a growing recognition that *interacting with* data can be just as productive as *categorizing* it.

Building on this shift, Nguyen-Trung and Nguyen's (2025) *Narrative-Integrated Thematic Analysis* (NITA) offers a more developed and structured analytic framework that moves beyond coding without fully leaving behind thematic traditions. Rather than segmenting data into coded units, the analysis process begins with the identification of high-level themes across interviews, followed by the construction of individual narrative profiles for each respondent. These profiles are then compared and synthesized into cross-case narratives, allowing the AI to surface commonalities, contrasts, and recurring motifs.

Throughout the process, the researcher remains in control—curating AI suggestions, refining theme boundaries, and evaluating the coherence of emergent storylines. The AI is not treated as an authority or human-like collaborator, but as one operative element within a broader interpretive process. When prompted effectively, it can generate alternative framings, surface contrasts, or propose tentative associations that researchers may then interrogate, refine, or dismiss.

NITA reflects a transitional model: one foot in the familiar world of theme development and the other stepping toward a new paradigm of AI-assisted narrative construction. It acknowledges that interpretive insight can emerge not from labeling discrete data fragments, but from engaging with participants' accounts as a whole. In this configuration, synthesis emerges through structured human judgment acting upon machine-generated possibilities, preserving the interpretive logic of thematic analysis while reducing dependence on manual coding and fixed categorical structures.

Together, these approaches suggest that qualitative research is entering a moment of methodological experimentation. Their work points to the same core insight: that dialogue—not classification—may become the foundation of future analysis. Building on these emerging practices, Conversational Analysis with AI (CA^{AI}—read: *CA to the power of AI*) takes the next step: reimagining the analytic process itself around human–AI dialogue.

CA to the Power of AI: A Methodological Framework for Dialogic Analysis in the Age of LLMs

In the following, I present a methodological framework called Conversational Analysis with AI, or "CA to the Power of AI (CA^{AI})," developed in response to growing recognition that coding may no longer be necessary as the central organizing mechanism of qualitative analysis. The framework emerged from extensive experimentation with standalone chatbots, AI integrations in QDAS software

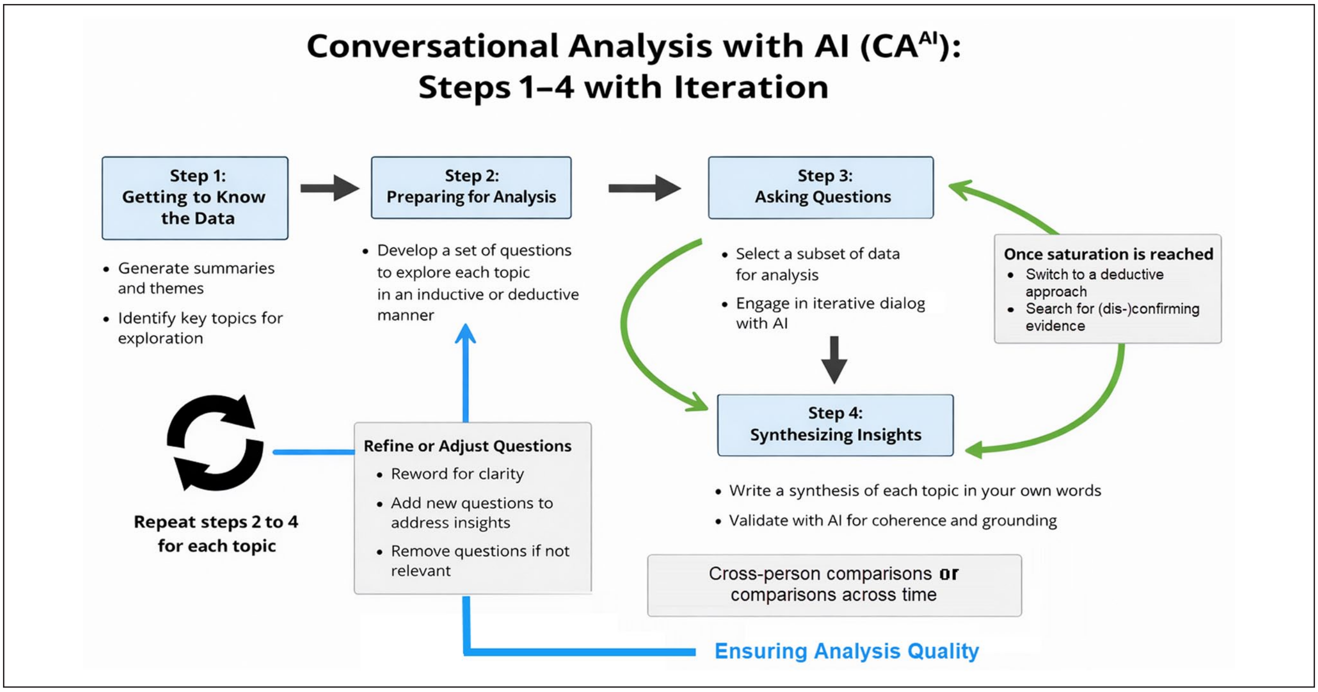

Figure 1. Steps 1 to 4 of Conversational Analysis With AI.

(such as MAXQDA and ATLAS.ti), and the development of my own platform, QInsights (QInsights BV, 2025). CA^{AI} is organized around four iterative steps (Figure 1), with an optional fifth step for researchers pursuing conceptual or theoretical development.

I describe CA^{AI} as a methodological framework rather than a method. It does not prescribe a single analytic tradition but provides a structured way to embed dialogic interaction with large language models (LLMs) within diverse qualitative approaches. It recognizes that when analysis is conducted dialogically with an AI system, knowledge no longer arises solely within a dyadic researcher–data relationship. Instead, it emerges within a triadic configuration, in which the AI acts as a generative mechanism that produces associative outputs, which the researcher then interrogates, interprets, and positions analytically.

The framework is grounded in a relational–constructivist ontology, in which reality is viewed as interpreted rather than discovered, and meaning is produced through interaction. Epistemologically, CA^{AI} aligns with a hermeneutic interpretivist tradition in which understanding develops through iterative interpretation. By extending this hermeneutic stance to include AI-mediated interaction, the framework draws on a distributed view of meaning-making: sense emerges not from human cognition alone but through interpretive engagement with AI-generated textual associations that are evaluated, reframed, and contextualized by the researcher. Here, the human remains the interpreting subject, while the AI functions as a mediating element rather than an autonomous knower.

While the examples in this chapter focus on interview transcripts, the dialogic structure of CA^{AI} applies equally to other forms of unstructured qualitative data, including focus group discussions, observational field notes, and documents.

Step 1: Getting to Know the Data

To ask meaningful questions and engage productively in dialogue with the data, the researcher must first develop a sufficient level of familiarity with the material. This may involve preparing or verifying transcripts, including correcting AI-generated ones when necessary. Summaries produced by AI can be helpful at this stage by offering a rapid orientation to the overall content. However, because LLMs operate non-deterministically—producing slightly different outputs even when given the same prompt multiple times—such summaries should be treated as provisional aids for initial orientation rather than as fully reliable analytical outcomes.

An additional strategy for initial familiarization involves generating preliminary themes, a task at which LLMs are particularly effective. Whereas human analysts typically need to segment large datasets into smaller units to manage cognitive load, LLMs can process extensive bodies of text in a single pass, provided they fall within the model's context window (currently ranging from approximately 200 to

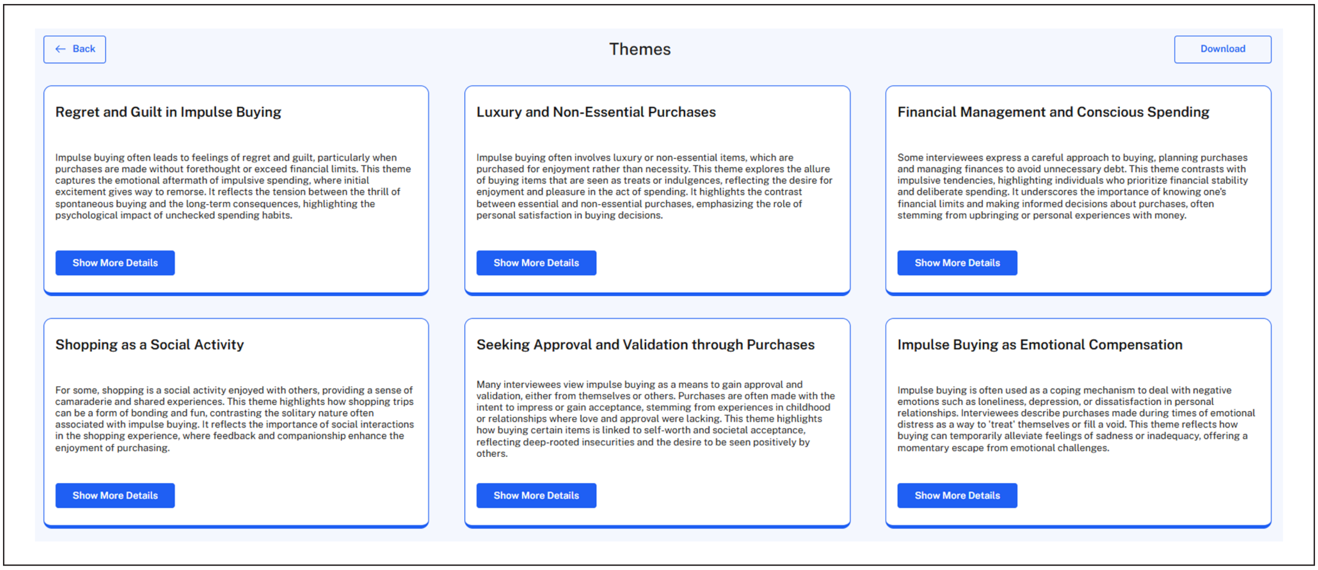

Figure 2. Suggested Topics (Screenshot: QInsights Themes Analysis).

500 pages). Their internal processing is based on vector representations of words and phrases, allowing them to detect semantic relationships and patterns across large numbers of sentences simultaneously. This enables them to surface recurrent ideas that may be distributed across multiple documents or expressed in varied linguistic forms, producing what is essentially an overarching, holistic scan of the dataset.

Figure 2 illustrates how thematic suggestions appear in the current version of QInsights (QInsights BV, 2025). Selecting the option to "Show More Details" reveals the exact segments from the original source materials that were used by the model to generate each theme. The themes offered at this stage are not intended as conclusive findings but as prompts for further exploration. Due to the stochastic nature of LLMs, repeated analyses of the same dataset typically produce some variation. The degree of variation can be influenced through the temperature setting. In QInsights, with the temperature set to a low 0.2, theme generation shows approximately 80% overlap across runs. Therefore, the advice is to conduct the theme generation process three times. The researcher then determines which themes to interrogate further during Step 2. Alternatively, the AI-generated themes may be used simply as a navigational scaffold or content map, guiding attention while allowing theoretically driven interests to shape the analytic trajectory.

Step 2: Preparing for Analysis

Researchers select one topic to start with and develop a set of exploratory questions to guide the interaction with the LLM. These questions may be inductive, open-ended prompts that allow patterns to emerge organically from the data, or deductive, shaped by existing theoretical frameworks or prior findings. In both cases, the aim is to surface relevant data segments and support meaningful interpretation aligned with the researcher's analytic intent.

While it can be helpful to brainstorm the questions with the AI assistant, the final selection and wording of questions is firmly in the hands of the researcher. This question set functions as the analytical scaffolding for the topic and provides a basis for transparency and replicability. For this reason, CA^{AI} proceeds topic by topic rather than through an unstructured stream of questioning. When researchers simply "dive in" and ask whatever comes to mind, the result is often a long and disorganized sequence of dialogue that becomes increasingly difficult to navigate. Without a defined topical structure, it quickly becomes unclear where specific questions were asked, how the inquiry progressed, or how interpretations developed. Such fragmentation undermines systematic analysis and makes both reflection and validation unnecessarily challenging.

In the dataset used here for illustration, the topic chosen for analysis is one of the above-identified themes: *Seeking approval and validation through purchase*. To explore this topic, the following set of guiding questions was developed:

- What explanations do respondents offer for making purchases they later regretted or found excessive?
- How do respondents describe the emotional state or life situation they were in before and after these purchases?

- In what ways do respondents connect their buying decisions to social expectations or a desire for external validation?

At this early stage of the dialogic analysis, it is important to build from the ground up. This means beginning with descriptive questions rather than immediately asking about relationships, typologies, or direct answers to the research questions. This is a common mistake I have observed in research practice, one that can ultimately result in the dismissal of generative AI as a viable tool (Nguyen & Welch, 2025). An LLM will always provide an answer, no matter how badly instructed or premature the question.

This gradual progression—from descriptive questioning toward later synthesis (Step 4)—helps the researcher to follow the path of meaning as it unfolds, rather than skipping straight to conclusions. In this way, the analysis becomes both systematic and deeply grounded in the data. This also helps to overcome the "black box" feeling—the sense that the LLM is simply producing an answer without any transparency about how it was generated.

If it aligns with your research goals, consider ending each dialogue by requesting a case-based summary or an integrative summary that draws together perspectives across all respondents. You can also ask the AI assistant to highlight similarities and differences between respondents and to identify any unique or divergent viewpoints:

- Write a summary in essay format about (respondent name), focusing on . . . . Include direct quotes with page numbers to support key points and maintain the respondent's authentic voice.
- How do these respondents differ, and what do they have in common?
- Do any respondents offer a unique or divergent perspective?

Step 3: Selecting Data to Analyze and Asking Questions

While it is technically possible to process 20 or more 1-hr interview transcripts at once, doing so tends to result in generalized responses. Generative AI models are prone to summarizing rather than analyzing when faced with large-scale input, which can smooth over important nuances. For this reason, it is best to begin with a focused subset of the data—typically four to six interviews, and rarely more than 10 at a time, depending on length and complexity. Starting small allows the researcher to stay close to the data and retain greater control over the analytic process.

In this step, the researcher engages the AI assistant in a dialogic exchange using the questions developed in Step 2. AI responses are not treated as definitive answers but as openings for deeper exploration—prompting follow-up questions, requests for clarification, comparisons across cases, or challenges to initial impressions. Through this interactive back-and-forth, interpretation begins to take shape—not as something delivered by the AI, but as a process the researcher actively guides and participates in.

Typically, researchers engage in inductive or deductive reasoning during this step, depending on how the initial questions were framed. However, when unexpected findings arise—observations that challenge assumptions or fall outside existing conceptual frameworks—abductive reasoning becomes particularly valuable. First described by Charles Sanders Peirce, abduction refers to the process of developing the most plausible explanations for puzzling or surprising observations. Researchers may notice contradictions, outliers, or unexpected statements, either intentionally sought or discovered serendipitously, which then lead to the formulation of tentative hypotheses. They can involve the AI assistant to:

- ask exploratory questions to probe anomalies (e.g., Why might respondents with similar experiences express contrasting emotions?).
- brainstorm plausible explanations, drawing from cultural, psychological, organizational, or contextual perspectives.
- iterate between data and hypotheses to refine, challenge, or expand emerging ideas.
- compare across subgroups to explore whether patterns hold across different contexts.

This dialogic exchange—whether guided by inductive, deductive, or abductive reasoning—gradually shapes interpretation. The researcher remains in control, using the AI to broaden perspectives, retrieve relevant data segments, and test emerging insights. Once a topic has been explored in sufficient depth, the process moves on to Step 4: Synthesizing Insights.

Step 4: Synthesizing Insights

When you ask an AI assistant questions about your data, it can generate pages of output in minutes. In the case of the *Approval & Validation through Shopping* dataset, the dialogic exploration across the three shopper types produced over 30 pages of text. It's like traveling by high-speed train: you cover a lot of ground quickly, but insight doesn't emerge at that speed. Your understanding—your capacity to reflect, synthesize, and integrate—needs time to catch up. This is where Step 4 comes in.

After completing the dialogic exploration in Step 3, the researcher slows down to engage deeply with the conversation(s). In QInsights, this can be done directly in the analysis archive or by exporting the dialog. I chose to export the material and read through it in a Word document—highlighting passages, writing comments in the margins, and noting emerging patterns. I returned to the AI conversations when I needed clarification or wanted to probe further. At times, I revisited the source documents to re-immerse myself in the data and contextualize insights. From here, there are two valid paths:

You may choose to write the synthesis yourself, grounding your interpretation in theory, experience, and contextual understanding. Or, you may prefer to co-develop the synthesis with the AI assistant by uploading the conversation as a new document and shaping a draft collaboratively.

In this dialogic mode, the researcher guides the AI assistant—not only in *what* to say, but in *how* to say it: what aspects to emphasize, which lens to apply, and how to structure the narrative. The AI assistant responds by recombining and reformulating the content based on this guidance, surfacing language or framings that the researcher can accept, reject, or revise. You might also challenge the model to identify weak spots, test counter-interpretations, or offer alternative perspectives.

In this way, the synthesis is neither a product of pure human reasoning nor a machine-generated artifact, but an emergent effect of what Deleuze and Guattari (1980) described as an assemblage—a heterogeneous configuration in which meaning arises through relations rather than from any single source. The LLM acts as an epistemic actor, not because it understands, but because it contributes distributed, intertextual associations that extend the researcher's own sense-making.

Insight, then, arises from the interplay between the data, the model, and the researcher, each shaping and reshaping the other through recursive dialogue. Importantly, this does not mean the researcher cedes interpretive authority. On the contrary, the strength of the synthesis depends on the reflexivity, methodological awareness, and theoretical grounding with which the researcher orchestrates the process.

This aligns CA^{AI} with a hermeneutic tradition in which understanding is constructed through iterative interpretation rather than discovered as a fixed truth. Reflexivity therefore becomes essential—not only in relation to personal assumptions and positionality, but also in relation to how prompts are designed, how AI outputs are framed, and how interpretive decisions are made throughout the dialogic process.

Looping Steps 3 and 4

When working with subgroups, the same set of questions is applied to each group individually. Each subgroup may reveal distinct nuances or reinforce patterns observed earlier. As the analysis unfolds, new insights accumulate, gradually contributing to a more comprehensive understanding of the topic.

In the example above, I worked with just three interviews per subgroup, so I began preparing the synthesis after exploring all three groups. If you're working with larger subgroups, it can be useful to alternate between Steps 3 and 4: complete the dialogic exploration for one subgroup, write a synthesis, then return to Step 3 for the next subgroup, and so on.

Crucially, the process is iterative, not fixed. While asking questions during Step 3, researchers may discover that something important was left out—or that a new line of inquiry emerges based on the AI's responses. In such cases, the original set of questions from Step 2 can be revised or expanded. These updated questions are then applied in the next loop, allowing the analysis to evolve in response to emerging findings.

When saturation is reached—meaning no new substantial insights emerge—researchers may transition into a more deductive mode in subsequent rounds, testing or refining earlier interpretations against new data. Once all subgroups have been analyzed, you can compare the syntheses across groups. To support this final comparison, consider uploading the individual syntheses as a combined document and asking your AI assistant to help identify overarching patterns or differences.

Once a topic has been thoroughly explored across all relevant subgroups, the researcher returns to Step 2 to develop a new set of questions, and the Step 3–4 loop begins again for the next topic.

Step 5: Elevating the Analysis

A possible Step 5 involves extending the dialogical process between data, researcher, and AI by incorporating explicit theoretical reasoning. At this stage, the objective is not merely to describe patterns but to engage in conceptual abstraction: identifying relationships between themes, integrating findings into existing theoretical frameworks, or contributing to the development of new theoretical insights.

In this phase, the AI assistant remains a valuable analytical resource by helping to surface patterns, suggest theoretical connections, and test emerging interpretations against the data. However, following the quality standards proposed by Strübing et al. (2018), it is the researcher's responsibility to ensure a dynamic, iterative interplay between theory and data—what they describe as "theoretical pervasiveness." Rather than applying theory mechanically or relying solely on AI-driven suggestions, researchers critically engage with both data and theoretical concepts, allowing each to "irritate" and refine the other.

Elevating the analysis thus means extending the assemblage of data, researcher and AI into the theoretical dimension—ensuring that findings are not only empirically grounded but also conceptually robust and capable of contributing original insights to the broader scientific conversation.

There are several ways to approach this with the support of an AI assistant. One option is for the researcher to identify and articulate relationships or patterns that seem to emerge across the various topic-level syntheses. These hypotheses can then be tested or explored further in dialogue with the AI by revisiting the data, examining additional examples, or asking targeted follow-up questions. Alternatively, the AI assistant can be prompted to suggest connections across themes, though this typically requires the researcher to provide the relevant syntheses as input, especially if the analysis is being continued in a new session, where prior context may no longer be available in the model's short-term memory.

Another approach is to relate findings to theory. Researchers may ask the AI whether a particular theoretical framework could be relevant to explaining the observed patterns. To avoid unreliable or overly general responses, researchers are advised to either provide a concise summary of the relevant theory or verify the AI's interpretation by asking it to explain the key components. With the theoretical groundwork in place, the AI assistant can then be used to explore how the findings align with the theory, where inconsistencies arise, or how the theory might be extended or adapted in light of the empirical insights.

Step 5 thus supports deeper reflection and meaning-making—whether through theory-driven interpretation, comparative exploration, or conceptual integration. It marks a shift from topic-level analysis to broader insight, allowing researchers to position their findings within broader scholarly or strategic frameworks.

Adapting Existing Methods Within the CA^{AI} Framework

The suggested framework also allows researchers to integrate procedural steps from traditions such as Grounded Theory, Thematic Analysis, or Narrative Inquiry. To illustrate how Grounded Theory procedures can be adapted within the CA^{AI} framework, consider the early stages of analysis. A researcher might begin with the first interview and identify concise but conceptually rich passages for exploration—paralleling the open coding phase described by Strauss and Corbin (2014). In CA^{AI}, this does not involve assigning formal codes to segments; instead, it involves "breaking open" the data through exploratory questioning. Grounded Theory typically relies on questions such as: Who is involved? What is happening? Under what conditions? With what actions and consequences? It also incorporates constant comparison, hypothetical reasoning (e.g., "What if . . .?"), and theoretical probing (e.g., "So what?" or "Under what circumstances does this change?"). These same question types can be used dialogically to prompt the AI to surface meanings, actions, and conditions embedded in the text.

As provisional concepts emerge, the researcher can then instruct the AI assistant to retrieve additional instances, explore variation, and compare contrasting expressions—supporting conceptual elaboration. What is traditionally referred to as axial coding, defined as relating categories and properties through iterative inductive and deductive reasoning, can likewise be conducted dialogically by using targeted prompts to explore relationships, test assumptions, and refine conceptual linkages. Throughout this process, no tagging or code assignment is required; instead, category development occurs through iterative questioning, data retrieval, and conceptual refinement, eventually enabling the identification of a potential core category that integrates the emerging analysis.

Qualitative content analysis can also be adapted within the CA^{AI} framework by rethinking the sequencing of category development. Traditionally, content analysis involves defining categories in advance and fitting data segments into these predetermined slots. In contrast, CA^{AI} turns this process on its head: researchers engage the AI assistant in a dialogic exploration of a topic, using structured questioning to surface the range of aspects, themes, and nuances present in the data.

Rather than coding data to match predefined categories, researchers first build a rich narrative understanding of the topic through dialogue. Only at the end of the process are categories and their dimensions abstracted—grounded directly in the content of the discussions (see Wibowo & Wiese, forthcoming, for an example). Building on this, thematic analysis within CA^{AI} takes the process one step further. After developing categories and identifying their dimensions, researchers can engage the AI assistant in a new phase of dialogue—searching for overarching themes that connect or transcend individual categories. Through structured, reflective questioning, researchers work with the AI to synthesize broader patterns of meaning, moving beyond description to higher levels of abstraction and interpretation.

Here again, the emphasis is not on mechanical extraction or classification, but on iterative, dialogic sense-making that fosters deeper, more coherent thematic development. Themes are not simply named; they are collaboratively constructed, tested, and refined through analytic conversation. In this way, CA^{AI} offers a pathway for both content and thematic analysis that preserves the integrity and depth of traditional methods, while embracing the flexibility, responsiveness, and epistemic openness of AI-supported dialogic inquiry.

However, while procedural elements can be adapted, the epistemological stance must also shift. CA^{AI} assumes a co-constructive view of knowledge rooted in relational and distributed processes rather than exclusively human-centered meaning-making. For instance, while Charmaz's Constructivist Grounded Theory represents a significant move toward subjectivity and reflexivity, it remains grounded in a model where meaning is ultimately generated within the human interpretive sphere (Charmaz, 2024). In contrast, CA^{AI} positions analysis as an assemblage—an emergent configuration in which meaning arises through the interaction of heterogeneous elements, including the researcher, the data, and the AI system. Here, the AI does not act as a conscious knower but as a probabilistic generator of intertextual associations that can be interrogated, affirmed, or rejected by the researcher within a socio-material context.

"Construction" in CA^{AI} is therefore not located solely in human cognition but is distributed across a dynamic interplay of interpretation, retrieval, contextualization, and synthesis. This distinction is crucial: adapting Grounded Theory within CA^{AI} is not a matter of transferring established procedures unchanged, but of reworking them to align with a relational, assemblage-oriented epistemology—one grounded in recursive orchestration and iterative meaning-making across human–AI interactions.

In sum, CA^{AI} supports methodological pluralism within a unified epistemic frame. It invites researchers to bring their analytic traditions into a new kind of conversation—not only with data, but with a model that extends, challenges, and reframes human understanding. Developing robust question-design practices for different analytic traditions remains an important next step in this evolving field.

Analytic Integrity in CA to the Power of AI

Ensuring rigor in CA^{AI} requires rethinking quality not as a function of coding agreement or procedural replication, but as a matter of maintaining integrity within a distributed, dialogic process of meaning-making. Because CA^{AI} is grounded in a relational–constructivist and assemblage-based epistemology, where understanding is co-constructed through iterative interaction between researcher, data, and AI-generated associations, traditional indicators such as fixed codebooks or intercoder agreement do not align with its analytic logic. Rather than verifying consistency through mechanical matching, CA^{AI} establishes rigor through reflexive coherence, transparency of analytic pathways, and traceable engagement with the source material.

The goal is not to eliminate interpretive variation, but to ensure that interpretive movement is accountable, grounded, and dialogically justified. The following strategies demonstrate how CA^{AI} operationalizes analytic integrity in practice. They include:

- grounding analysis in data-secure, RAG-based tools that allow verification of AI outputs;
- using topic-based question sets as scaffolds analogous to coding frames for structuring inquiry;
- maintaining full traceability through chat-based analytic records;
- enabling cross-person or temporal comparison of interpretive syntheses;
- configuring model parameters (e.g., temperature) to support interpretive stability; and
- embedding reflexivity as a continuous checkpoint across analytic cycles.

Each of these practices contributes to analytic rigor not by enforcing uniformity of outcome, but by supporting thoughtful, justifiable, and empirically anchored interpretation. and empirically anchored interpretation. See Table 1 for a summary of recommended practices to ensure quality in conversational analysis with AI.

Grounding Analysis by Using RAG-Based Tools

A core recommendation is to avoid using general-purpose chatbots for serious qualitative analysis, due to risks such as hallucinations and limited transparency about how responses are generated. While some specialized tools attempt to restrict the model's focus to uploaded documents through prompt engineering alone, this approach still carries a higher risk of fabricated content and incomplete traceability. Tools that use retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) architectures offer a more reliable solution. In a RAG system, the model's outputs are explicitly grounded in specific passages retrieved from the user's own data, greatly reducing hallucination risk and enhancing transparency about how responses are constructed. Researchers can directly inspect which segments informed each response, enabling validation at the level of source material.

Using Topic-Based Question Sets as Analytical Scaffolds

Since CA^{AI} does not rely on coding, it does not assess reliability through inter- or intra-coder agreement—a metric traditionally used in some qualitative traditions, though questioned within interpretive paradigms. Rather than coding units, the central structuring device in CA^{AI} is the topic-based question set. These questions function analogously to a coding frame—not by assigning labels to segments, but by defining the conceptual pathways through which a topic is explored. These questions sets structure of the analytic process and offer a stable basis for assessing consistency.

The entire sequence of questions, AI responses, and researcher reflections is documented in the chat protocol (see Figure 3). This provides a full audit trail of how interpretations were developed, including the reasoning behind each analytic move. In contrast to traditional coding systems, where the final code assignment often obscures the thought process behind it, the dialogic record makes researchers' interpretive pathways visible and reviewable.

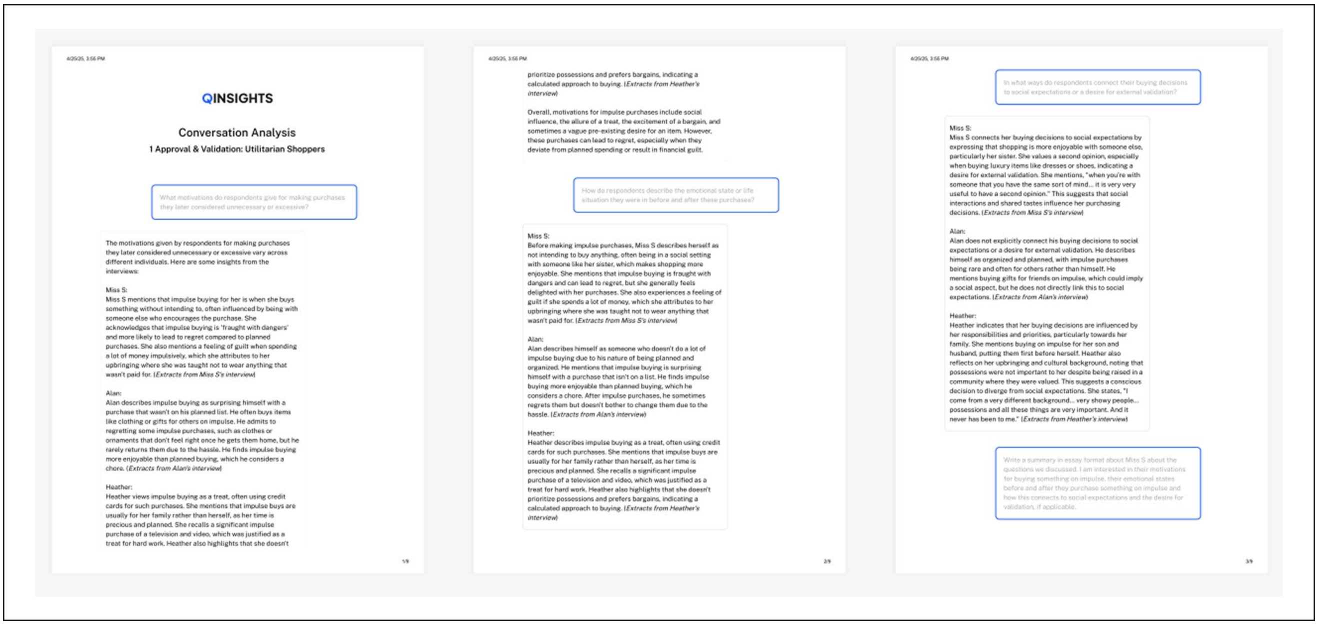

Figure 3. Chat Protocol Serving for Later Synthesis, Also Adding Transparency to the Analysis Process.

This added transparency strengthens the validity of findings by allowing for critical scrutiny, replication of questioning strategies, and deeper reflexivity.

Cross-Person Comparison

To ensure analysis quality, the same question set can be used by two analysts independently. Both pose the same prompts to the AI assistant, then write their own syntheses based on the AI-generated responses. These syntheses can then be compared and discussed, providing evidence of reliability, or if you work within an interpretive tradition, credibility and confirmability:

- Did the AI return consistent or divergent responses?
- Did both researchers interpret the outputs in similar or contrasting ways?
- Where did the AI appear to align too readily with assumptions embedded in the prompt (sycophancy)?
- Did questioning styles unintentionally lead the AI toward specific conclusions, and were these tendencies critically interrogated?

This form of dialogic review helps researchers identify blind spots, surface prompt-induced bias, and detect instances where the AI may have mirrored the researcher's framing rather than providing substantive variation. It mirrors the intent of intercoder dialogue by enabling collaborative scrutiny but shifts the focus from coding agreement to the integrity of interpretive synthesis. Question sets may then be refined, reworded, expanded, or pruned in light of these comparative insights.

Comparison Over Time

For solo researchers, a quality check can be performed by repeating the same analytic sequence after a short interval. The researcher reuses the original question set, engages the AI, and writes a second synthesis for comparison. While not a perfect replication strategy, this approach helps assess whether AI responses are stable over time and whether the researcher's own interpretation remains coherent across analytic cycles.

The temperature setting of the language model plays a critical role in determining output stability. Lower temperatures reduce randomness, resulting in more predictable and consistent responses. Dedicated tools for qualitative analysis typically allow researchers to configure these parameters; a temperature setting between 0.2 and 0.5 is generally advisable for interpretive work. By contrast, general-purpose chatbots such as ChatGPT (which typically operates at around 0.7) are optimized for creative variation and therefore tend to produce greater inconsistency across sessions.

In sum, CA^{AI} shifts the focus of quality assurance away from mechanical agreement toward reflexive interpretive rigor. Researchers do not accept AI outputs at face value, but engage with them critically, revisiting the source, questioning assumptions, and refining analytic directions. This not only mitigates the risks of hallucination or misinterpretation, but also aligns with core qualitative values: transparency, reflexivity, and accountability.

In this sense, CA^{AI} does not compromise core qualitative values but reinterprets and operationalizes them for an AI-supported research environment. The emphasis on dialogic engagement, traceability to empirical data, theoretical

Table 1. Strategies for Ensuring Quality in CA^{AI}.

Quality criterion	CA^{AI} strategy
Validity / Credibility	Traceability to source data (via RAG); triangulation across groups; iterative question refinement; negative case analysis
Transparency / Traceability	Full documentation of dialogic interactions via chat protocols; visible interpretive pathways; audit trail of analytic decisions; explicit synthesis writing showing how meaning was developed
Stability / Coherence	Reuse of topic-based question sets over time or across analysts; comparison of syntheses to assess interpretive stability; temperature control to regulate LLM variation; dialogic review to identify divergence or sycophancy
Reflexivity / Interpretive Accountability	Continuous researcher engagement with AI outputs; synthesis written in the researcher's own voice; critical evaluation of emerging insights

sensitivity, and reflexive documentation closely aligns with quality principles identified by Strübing et al. (2018). Their call for dynamic, empirically grounded, and theoretically informed processes—rather than rigid proceduralism—finds a contemporary expression within CA^{AI}'s synthesis-driven approach. By embedding AI into an iterative analytic triangle of data, researcher, and assistant, CA^{AI} maintains the integrity of qualitative inquiry while adapting it to new technological possibilities.

Ethical and Authorship Considerations

As the boundary between human and machine authorship becomes more fluid, ethical questions emerge around transparency, credit, and responsibility. If an AI model contributes to the generation of analytical text, to what extent should this be acknowledged? Who owns the insight? And how do we ensure that the resulting analysis remains accountable to the standards of qualitative research?

In the CA to the Power of AI approach, the researcher remains the primary author—even when language is co-generated. The AI's contributions are always mediated by the researcher's theoretical lens, methodological choices, and interpretive judgment. While the model may suggest formulations, surface associations, or offer possible framings, it is the researcher who decides which elements are meaningful and why. Authorship lies not in who generates the text, but in who confers significance.

Transparency is essential. Researchers should make visible how AI was used, for example, by disclosing the question sets employed and the resulting chat transcripts or analytic trails. Such documentation reveals the dialogic and iterative nature of the meaning-making process and allows others to evaluate the integrity and rigor of the analysis.

Researchers must remain aware of the model's characteristics: its lack of lived experience, its tendency to reproduce dominant discourses, and its potential for sycophancy, hallucination, or bias. The CA^{AI} framework and workflow were designed with these limitations in mind. Rather than assuming full AI literacy, the framework implicitly guides researchers toward appropriate use—for example, by positioning AI-generated themes as starting points for inquiry rather than final results, by suggesting systematic ways to engage with the data, by offering guidance on how to formulate questions, and by structuring meaning-making as a step-by-step process.

As in conventional qualitative analysis, analytic and interpretive skill develops over time. Recognizing bias—whether in one's own interpretations or in the AI's responses—depends on researcher reflexivity, methodological sensitivity, and growing interpretive awareness. The framework supports this development, but it does not replace the need for critical judgment.

While QInsights is not required to implement the CA^{AI} framework, platform choice has ethical implications. As outlined earlier, general-purpose chatbots raise concerns around privacy, data control, and the opacity of response generation. By contrast, purpose-built environments such as QInsights offer clearer accountability structures: data are processed within defined jurisdictions, remain isolated from other users, and are not used to train foundation models. This controlled infrastructure supports ethical stewardship of sensitive materials and reinforces transparency in how analytic outputs are generated. Moreover, the ability to trace each response back to specific data excerpts—illustrated in Figure 4—strengthens authorship accountability by allowing researchers to justify their interpretive choices in relation to source material.

Paradigm Shifts in Qualitative Analysis: Toward a Post-Coding Era

The analysis method presented in this article, Conversational Analysis with AI (CA^{AI}), is not merely a procedural innovation—it marks a deeper paradigmatic shift in how qualitative research can be conceived in the age of generative AI. While it challenges the long-standing assumption, dominant in coding-based approaches, that systematic segmentation is a necessary precondition for rigorous interpretation, it also resonates with interpretive and

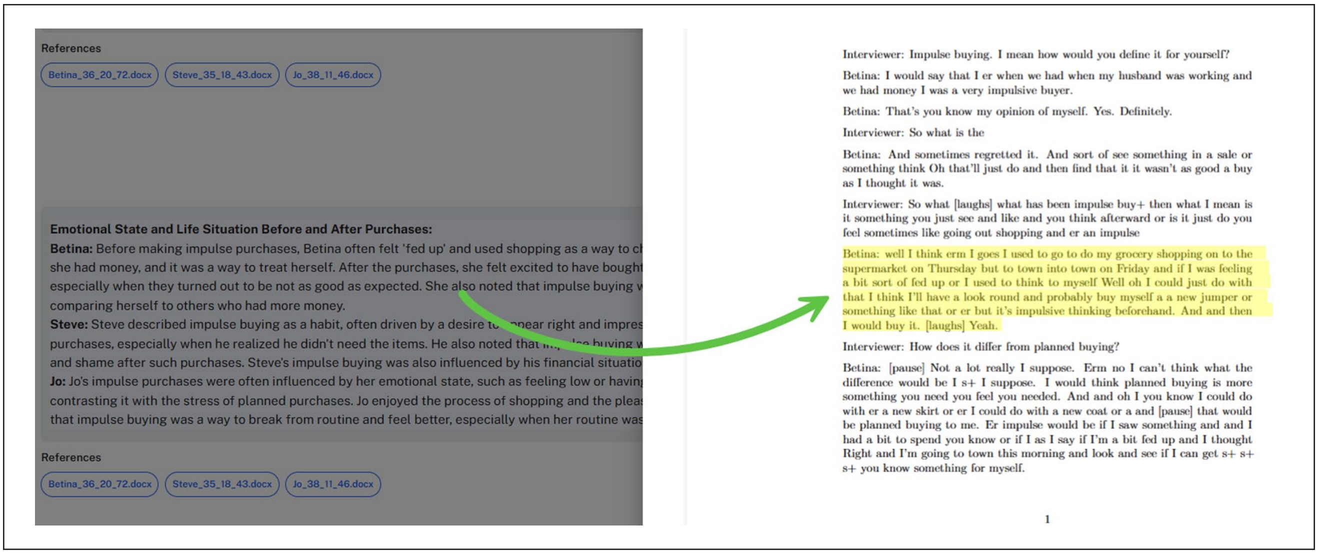

Figure 4. Validation of AI Responses Within the Original Source Data in QInsights.

reconstructive traditions that have historically emphasized the primacy of meaning-making over coding. CA^{AI} offers a model in which meaning is co-constructed through structured, iterative dialogue with a large language model.

Other recent approaches signal a move in this direction. Krähnke et al. (2025), for example, propose a hybrid method that integrates multiple LLMs into an abductive heuristic process. Their approach treats each model as an independent epistemic actor and constructs meaning through triangulated interaction. It is dialogic, theoretically grounded, and epistemologically reflexive. In this respect, their method stands as a methodological cousin to CA^{AI}. Both approaches emphasize abductive reasoning, iterative engagement, and the researcher's central interpretive role.

Yet while Krähnke et al.'s process involves multiple model perspectives and comparative logic, CA^{AI} operates with a single model and positions the researcher as the sole interpretive agent who orchestrates the analytic dialogue. The emphasis shifts from epistemic triangulation between models to epistemic orchestration through researcher-led questioning. Meaning emerges not through codebook consensus or inter-model dialogue, but through recursive, layered interaction between analyst, data, and model—guided by reflexive judgment and evolving lines of inquiry.

This reconfiguration marks a paradigm shift (Friese, 2025). Rather than treating AI as an assistant to accelerate coding or classification, CA^{AI} dispenses with coding altogether. It replaces segmentation and labeling with *questioning and synthesis*. It replaces the logic of breakdown and categorization with a logic of interpretive flow, contextual grounding, and iterative refinement.

Epistemologically, CA^{AI} extends the hermeneutic frame discussed earlier. Knowing is no longer constructed solely through immersion and memoing, but through *conversation*. The AI model acts as a dialogic instrument—not because it understands in a human sense, but because its outputs reflect distributed, intertextual exposure to the lifeworlds researchers seek to understand. As Krähnke et al. argue, LLMs function as abductive catalysts. In CA^{AI}, this potential is fully embraced—but on the condition that the human researcher remains the analytic engine. The model provokes; the human interprets.

This shift has methodological, pedagogical, and ethical consequences. It requires researchers to learn a new craft: not coding but constructing analytic dialogue. It redistributes skill from segmentation to synthesis, from code creation to conceptual orchestration. It alters transparency practices—making question sets, iterative refinements, and synthesis rationales the new basis of analytic traceability. And it calls for new norms around interpretive authority, prompting researchers to continuously reflect on how AI responses are used, rejected, or shaped within their analytic framework.

Rather than offering yet another way to speed up qualitative analysis, *CA to the Power of AI* reframes what analysis is. It proposes that coding is not intrinsic to qualitative rigor, and that a coding-free, dialogic methodology can meet or exceed existing standards of transparency, reflexivity, and depth. It does not simply revise old practices. It reimagines them.

Conclusion

Conversational Analysis with AI (CA^{AI}) marks a turning point in the evolution of qualitative research. Rather than retrofitting generative AI into existing coding-based workflows, it reimagines the analytic process around dialogic engagement—placing interpretation, not categorization, at the center. This shift reframes the researcher's role from a coder of segments to a conductor of analytic conversation, guiding the AI through structured, reflexive inquiry.

By moving away from segmentation and embracing synthesis, CA^{AI} unlocks new forms of analytical depth, flexibility, and traceability. It preserves the core values of qualitative inquiry while adapting them to a technological landscape shaped by distributed cognition and iterative interaction. CA^{AI} does not dilute rigor; it redistributes it. And in doing so, it challenges long-standing assumptions about what constitutes qualitative analysis and how knowledge is constructed.

Leveraging the strengths of large language models for data retrieval and synthesis, CA^{AI} keeps the researcher firmly in control—through structured questioning, interpretive judgment, and iterative refinement. This approach offers not only gains in efficiency and flexibility but also invites a fundamental reconsideration of epistemological assumptions and validation practices within qualitative inquiry.

For those willing to step beyond coding and embrace AI as a generative mediator within the interpretive process, CA^{AI} offers a compelling alternative. Its promise lies in its capacity to deepen interpretation, democratize analytic access, and expand the epistemic horizon of qualitative research in the age of artificial intelligence.

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Susanne Friese is a scholar of qualitative methods with extensive experience in research and teaching. She has contributed to the development of computer assisted analysis and now focuses on how genAI can support reflective, transparent, and rigorous qualitative work. She speaks and writes widely on the future of qualitative inquiry, arguing for approaches that preserve methodological rigour while opening new possibilities for working with qualitative data.